UK Data Service

Pioneers

of Qualitative Research

Maxine Molyneux

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2017

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

UK Data Archive, University of Essex, Colchester. November 2018

SN 6226 - Pioneers of Social Research, 1996-2012. Depositor: Thompson, P.
Copyright British Library

Table of Contents

1: Childhood and Empire: Out of the Ex-Pat Bubble 3

2: Race and Class Tension in Colonial India 6

3: Sociology from a Transnational Perspective 7

4: Joining a Political Generation 8

5: Sociology at Essex 10

6: Developing a Gender Perspective 11

7: Working for a Better World: Ethics and Religion 12

8: State Socialism, Gender and Development 13

9: Researching first generation women factory workers in Yemen 14

10: Women in a Socialist Yemen 16

11: Innovation and Isolation: Development, Feminism, Anthropology and Social Policy 19

12: Afghanistan and Yemen: Dangers in Fieldwork 20

13: Researching Marxist-Leninism in Ethiopia 21

14: Women in the Age of Perestroika 23

15: Nicaragua, Gender and Revolution 24

16: Mothers and Social Protection in Latin America, Africa and the Middle East 26

Maxine Molyneux

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

27 July 2017

1: Childhood and Empire: Out of the Ex-Pat Bubble

I was born in Pakistan in 1948, a year after Indian Independence, and Karachi was as relatively safe place, despite all the horrors of the mass migration caused by partition. So I grew up, for those few years, as a very small infant, in a very tranquil setting, brought up largely by a very nice ayah, and so we stayed in Pakistan for a short while, and then my father was posted to England.

My father had wanted to be a pilot. He was in the RAF, but his eyesight wasn't good enough, and so he went into the engineering section of aviation, and so by the time I was born, he had become responsible for setting up the Indian route, or at least participating in the setting-up of the Indian route, so I think he had a spell in Imperial Airways and then BOAC, which then became British Airways...

I couldn't confide in my parents, but I think, as an only child I was mostly brought up by ayahs in India, and I was very close to, to the maids in Latin America, who were a little bit older than me, so they were my immediate confidantes and the people I spent naughty time with. Because I would go off and sit in the servants' quarters which were forbidden to me, and so the people who I [was close to] immediately, in terms of emotional relevance, were those people. And I retained some fondness for some of them, and remember them all very well.

But no, it was a very small family, so there were three of us, we were constantly living abroad or, or in temporary accommodation when my father came back to train, and I would be put in a local school for six months, eight months or a year, and so close friends and relatives there weren't, because we were constantly on the move. No, I can't say I had any confidantes, actually. I think I was quite a solitary child, apart from the people who worked in the house.

That made me into somebody who enjoyed reading, and I was quite happy to go off on my own and explore places and things. In an odd sort of way, although my parents were very disciplinarian, they weren't invigilating every move I made, so I was able to go off and

play on building sites … I climbed trees, I went playing on the rocks in India, things like this which, today, parents would be horrified about, but it was a very good experience I would say…

My grandmother I knew because my father wanted to come back every year and spend Christmas with her. So we would come back every year or every other year sometimes, to stay at my grandmother's house, and that was my first experience of England, coming back to this freezing cold country, often in smog, and being holed up in this little two-up/two-down terrace in Rochester, for what seemed, to me, interminable periods of time… I loved my grandmother, she was very kind to me, and very warm…

So there was Pakistan for a few years, then there was Bristol for one and a half years or so, then we went to Bombay, and we stayed until 1959. I went to Walsingham House School, which was a former school under the British Raj – very grand, it was an old maharajah's palace, and it had been taken over, of course, by the Indian government after Independence, and so it had a split curriculum. So we did the English curriculum in the morning and the Indian curriculum in the afternoon, where I learnt some Hindi and about the river Ganges, and the anopheles mosquito and all sorts of Indian things, and in the morning we did roughly follow some kind of English school curriculum. In the morning we sang in the music classes, "There'll always be an England", and in the afternoon, then the Indian ones, "There'll always be an India", to exactly the same tune, but slightly altered words! So it was a very good multi-positional, if you like, education. So I liked that school, it was an interesting place to be. Again, very disciplinarian. We used to march round the compound, in formation, every afternoon, and sit in rows for half an hour after lunch. I'm sure this was again something practised in English public schools and handed over to us to continue the legacy…

I left when I must have been coming on for 11, because, again, my father had to come back to England because aviation was making such great strides, if you were an engineer you had to bone up on the latest developments. So we came to England, … I sat the 11+ and I then went to a grammar school, Sunbury Grammar School. We were living in Hanwell, in a lovely, lovely place, called Tudor Court, it was one of Henry VIII's hunting lodges, but [now] divided into flats. It just happened that BOAC had some kind of lease on a couple of flats for people like in my father's position. So I enjoyed that. Had a lovely tree I used to climb up, after school, and take a book and read, and suck Jubblys. Then it was Latin America after that.We first went to Argentina, and I went to school in Buenos Aires, to Northlands?? (13.00 sp) which was another one of these Anglo-Argentine schools, and it was a bit of a St.

Trinian's atmosphere there! We were all slightly rebellious and wore our uniforms in a rakish way and got into trouble, and endless detentions. But it was also a happy time because I went to riding school on the weekends when I wasn't having detentions, and there was lots of swimming and good things to do. For me, a fairly good time.

Not so much for my mother, who was very unhappy, and, indeed, she did have a nervous breakdown, and things were not very good. She didn't speak the language. She felt socially ill-at-ease, I think. She didn't know anybody, and the people she knew she didn't get on with. She was isolated. I was at school, my father was at work long hours, and there she was, stuck in this house with a maid who was rather elderly, who tyrannised her! She felt very persecuted.

Anyway, we moved from this place to a better place, and things settled down. It was a very good posting for my father. He had responsibility for the Southern Cone, so Uruguay, Argentina, and Chile. So we spent some time in Buenos Aires, and a few years later we moved across to Montevideo, to Uruguay. I moved school again, and went to the British School in Montevideo, which was a very good school, and that was for a couple of years…

But those years in Latin America were very formative, I think, because I did have a very supportive teacher. Things at home were not very – let's say tranquil – so she was very supportive of me, and I think she knew what I was going through at home. She … would lend me books and took an interest, which wasn't so much the case at home. I mean, I would get prizes in India and nobody would come to the prize-giving, for example. It was odd about my parents, they didn't think it was terribly important somehow. I was expected just to get on with it.

So it was a good environment, and when I came to, back to England, my father didn't really want to be in England, he had to do his training and then he wanted to be off again to another posting, because they lived much better abroad. I mean, the salaries were not that good, we were never rich. We had this oddly inflated lifestyle because we were part of the ex-pat community, but we were never well-off. I think my parents always felt the impact of their own experience – neither of them were born into prosperous families, by any means, and had like everybody else, suffered in the War. So I think my parents were quite anxious to get back out of England, and on the trail again.

But I had to do my 'A' Levels, so my father said, “Look, you know, you can do them, do them in a year. Do your 'A' Levels”… I was at a college called Slough College… But that was a very, extremely tricky year, because things had got very bad with my parents, and I ended up running away from home, and living in a squat, and trying to earn money in the

evenings and weekends, so that I could continue at the college. I also had a period in hospital, so I was really in a not very good situation. But I did get all my 'A' Levels, and my 'O' Levels – some miracle – and I wanted to go to university.

My father wasn't very keen on it, so, I think he didn't want to prolong his time in England, and he also didn't think it was worthwhile going to university – for me. So he said, "Well, all right, but you've got to go and get a job. Why don't you take something like secretarial training and I'll pay for that. But not, I'm not - three years in university, no". So I found a course in Westminster College in London. I had strength in languages, … and it was a course for interpreters and translators, a very good course. I learnt shorthand and typing, on my father's insistence, as well, which stood me in good stead when I became a journalist soon after. So that was a year. I would have been just 18. So I started looking for jobs, and I got jobs doing things like translating, and actually editing, so it was a time when you could get jobs relatively easily, and that was very good. So it was languages that really got me that first rung on the job market. (1, pp.1-7)

2: Race and Class Tension in Colonial India

India was the most formative experience in that sense, because, as I said, we lived in a kind of ex-pat bubble. The school, indeed, was, by then, admitting lots of Indians from, I imagine, fairly privileged families, but we were quite segregated. I think there was only one Indian in I think there was only one Indian [in my form] in my last year at Walsingham House School in Bombay and never more than one or two before that. We had Japanese, we had people from all over the world, but there weren't very many Indians – and one Indian, he was a prince. So it was a very segregated sort of life, and my parents lived in this ex-pat bubble. They and I spent a huge amount of time in "the Club" [Breach Candy] - a big swimming pool, my mother sat under an umbrella all day, drinking gin, as far as I can ascertain. And I would come from school and have a swim.

So there was that world, and then the world of India, which was very different… My earliest memories are to do with things like seeing lepers, to do with riots in the street, there was a kind of generalised fear of civil unrest, because there was quite a lot of it in Bombay. And one had this sense of a slightly risky world, that was outside of the bubble of the compound, or the ex-pat world – which was much more exciting than the languors of the swimming pool. This is why being able to escape that world and somehow get out of it - and

there were ways one could do that, one could just go and talk to people in the street. One could. I took huge risks, looking back on it now, about where I played, or where I went. I never had any experience of trouble, but I was constantly fascinated by and wanting to know more about the land that lay beyond the four walls of where we were all interred, so to speak! And that, I think, stayed with me – that sense of fascination…

So I was very aware of the prejudices of the British ex-pat communities, and really disliked it. Because, as I said, [it was] the people from the countries concerned who were my friends, who were my confidantes who I spent time with, who I enjoyed, who were generous to me… I can remember one horrifying incident. When we were leaving Bombay, so I would have been 10½/11'ish, the bearer, who is the person who waits at table, because the caste system means that you have a number of different people who only do certain jobs in the household - the bearer was particularly fond of me, and I of him, and I remember, at the airport, I rushed up to him, and I embraced him, and he embraced me, and we were weeping together, and it moves me even now. And my father just pulled me away, and said, "You don't do that" to him. And that symbolised something.

We went to the markets – not on my own – but my mother would go to the markets from time to time, and I knew a bit of Hindi, so I would always talk to people, and loved talking to people, and it was fascinating. I didn't feel it was a hostile world, whereas I think my parents did…

But you were aware of the social tensions in India, and the caste tensions. As a child, you grew up amidst them, and you could see the same caste and social tensions in the ex-pat community – you know, the people who were the diplomats, and the people, like my father, who were doing important work, but were not part of diplomatic circles, and I think my mother found all that world of cocktail parties where she didn't feel she quite belonged, and I don't think my father did either. You could see and feel a lot of those social differences/divisions, the snobberies going on. (1, pp, 8-9)

3: Sociology from a Transnational Perspective

Your question really is about, did [living abroad as a child] give me a different perspective on what I was interested in? And I think to a degree it did, in the sense that I was always looking for how to see countries, other than Britain, through the lens of the theoretical interest that I

had. So sociology gave me a lot in terms of a theoretical understanding, and indeed a sociological understanding of the world, but the objects of analysis, for me, were somewhere else. They were always on the margin, they were always not in the mainstream I suppose one would say, and that must have come from my experience growing up, and the personality that develops alongside that much more diverse experience. So that, I think, is probably true, and indeed, what did I end up specialising in, but the global South – to put it broadly – but Latin America, and more broadly, the countries in the so-called "developing world". So that stayed with me really, as a very primary commitment, and to a large degree it still is. So I would say it's a lifelong sense of both understanding, possibly, those regions in a different way to people who haven't lived there, but equally feeling they were constantly in need of exploring. I felt the need to explore them more. (1, p. 11)

4: Joining a Political Generation

It was also the moment, we're now in, I suppose '69, quite political times. I wasn't involved at all in the Student Movement of '68, but the experiences of the changing social climate were very profoundly felt by my generation. You couldn't not be aware of the politicisation of everyday life, if you were young. And in the art world there was a lot going on there with the "Situationists", there were all kinds of art movements, and I was very interested in that. I'd always had a radical rebellious streak, I was on a CND march once when I was in England and supported the anti-apartheid movement, and all these kinds of things, and the Women's Liberation Movement later, of course. But the art world was quite political and I was getting very interested in all of that as well. So there were these two things. I was working in this very strange Illustrated County Magazine [Group], which published the *Tatler*. Can you imagine, I used to write for the *Tatler* occasionally! And yet there was this other real world going on which was much more interesting. I met an artist I lived with for about a year, who taught at St. Martin's School of Art.

So it was very much that moment before life changed again, which was when that period came to an end. I just wanted to go back and see [what I called then] real countries, and I just took off to Latin America. I wanted to go back to Argentina, I wanted to see what was happening there, there were a lot of interesting things happening in Argentina, and so I spent a number of months there, got very caught up in the politics of Argentina. I was trying to do some stories, one for the *Sunday Times*, one for somebody else. One was on the Nazis

in Argentina, another one was on the guerrilla struggles going on in Argentina. I went as a journalist to do those stories – a freelance journalist – and had an extraordinary time getting those stories, which were very formative, all that experience…

When you're established as a freelance writer, you know who to ring up, and you can just say, you've got a very good story. I did a little piece for the *Sunday Times.* Then things really shifted when I came back to England, because that's when *Seven Days* was being established, and I was involved in that and became the only female editor amongst seven editors, responsible for the Arts and Culture pages of *Seven Days*. *Seven Days* was a Left-wing Independent Left weekly, and so we ran for about 21 issues. We ran out of money. It was one of Anthony Barnett's projects… Anthony raised the money through campaigns like, "The Hundred Hundreds". People would be asked for £100. And then there were two or three bigger backers who got it going. So that was sort of '71/'72 actually, after I came back from Latin America, and … by the time *Seven Days* was coming to a close, I was by then able to go to university independently… And I was ready for it by then. I'd had enough of freelancing and the superficiality of what you could do, even in a decent article, so I really wanted time to think and read and write, and develop those ideas. So that was the next phase…

After I'd split up with the artist, … I moved into a Feminist, I won't say it was a commune, but we lived together. Sally Alexander, the historian, had a large house and a number of us lived with her, and we got involved in things like the Night Cleaners Campaign. … I was with Red Ladder for a while, which was a radical theatre group, and this was all part of my arts and culture world, because I'd stayed with them for a while. Just living with them. People lived off different things, as they do now – not by choice, of course – but you had a number of irons in the fire, and you did a number of things, and you got by because you didn't need to earn very much money in those days…

I was making good friends, and people who remained significant for some time. I met Fred Halliday in *Seven Days*. Well, I'd met him before actually, once. When he was working at *Black Dwarf* I'd taken some Argentine guerilla leaders to meet him, and had translated for him, we'd met some months before *Seven Days*. But during *Seven Days* I shared an office with Fred, and he was Foreign Editor and I was Arts Editor, and that's how we met, and so we stayed together after that. So, yes, made some very important friendships…

It was a time in the early seventies when there was quite a lot of discussion going on about theoretical issues, and I was very involved in a group called "Theoretical Practice", and through Theoretical Practice met, or knew about, or read, people like Paul Hirst and Mike

Gain and that group of Althusserians who became influential in my own thinking… Yes, and of course, Fred himself, who was a Middle Eastern specialist and was very intellectually stimulating and interesting, and some of the people around *New Left Review* and so on. So it was a very exciting intellectual time, and it was a very good moment, for that reason, for me to go and spend time reading and thinking – having had that kind of background. (1, pp. 12-15)

5: Sociology at Essex

I spent three years doing the undergraduate degree at Essex, and it was an exciting time because, again, the theory question, which was still very much my intellectual preoccupation, I guess, at that time, was very sharply profiled in Essex. There were people working with Althusserian ideas, or post-Althusserian ideas and critical Marxism, in a way that I found very interesting. And there was also the Bob Jessop Theory Group which I joined…

Ernesto Laclau was one of the reasons I went to Essex because I had known him prior to coming. In fact, we had set up a Committee for the Defence of Argentine Political Prisoners when I came back from Argentina from that trip in 1971, so yes, Ernesto was known to me, and I thought it would be a good idea to go to Essex because if he was teaching modern, contemporary Latin America – nobody else was, I couldn't find any other university that was doing contemporary Latin America… I was very much influenced also by Mick Mann I have to say, whose work I greatly respected… It was quite a broad Department, as you know, and there was the social history side which was also very compelling, there was the Althusserians, the Weberians, there was the class work, which was also fascinating, and David Lockwood's legacy [his work on class] there was very important. So it was a very good Department to be in, very stimulating, and I learnt a lot. I was very, very pleased to be there.

Of course, later I met Harold Wolpe, who was an important influence on me because, again, he became a very, a very dear friend. I mean, we used to travel up and down together, because we lived next door to each other, and so we could constantly be discussing politics and theory, and what was going on in South Africa, what was going on here, there, and everywhere. He was very, a very important friend and influence on me. And being right next door to the ANC leadership for, I don't know, twenty years, was itself, a very interesting stimulus to thinking about politics, social change, and so forth, which was really my passion, thinking about how to theorise and understand social change, especially from a gender

perspective...

Mary McIntosh also, of course, who I worked with when we founded *Feminist Review* in 1979, much later, but she was a colleague first – I'd met her really, I think, as a colleague… There were one or two [other] Feminists around, but I don't think necessarily close to me. I was quite a singular researcher really, I tended to get on with things, and my preoccupation, I suppose in my undergraduate work, was to try to develop a critical Feminist approach to the writings that I was engaging with. So that my very first publications actually came out of my essays that I wrote in, in Essex, as an undergraduate. All three of them, actually, were all things I'd written as essays, and then published in *New Left Review* and in various places. So it was a very good place to develop that kind of critical take from the Feminist perspective, because it was reading the important texts on the curriculum that one could see that they were gender blind, that they were androcentric and gender blind, so how would you re-write those accounts from a gender perspective? And that was the challenge in quite a lot of the theoretical work that I published. (1, pp. 16-17)

6: Developing a Gender Perspective

I think in some ways I've always had a very Feminist kind of rebellious critical eye, partly because of my own upbringing, and the way I was treated in my family, particularly over the university issue. Which I don't think I ever really forgave my father for - although as I said now, with great hindsight, I can see it did me some good, not going to university! So I've forgiven him in a way! But I guess I first started getting more political and therefore reading more in that whole period of the late sixties, when you had all those Feminist publications coming out, *Spare Rib*, and I was in that circle of people, I occasionally wrote for them, and so I was aware, I think, and then living at Sally's, and encountering Feminist politics was the moment, really, of lots of things coming together. So I wasn't writing very much about Feminism, I was thinking a lot about it and reading, and there wasn't much going on in the theory side, I mean, going to theoretical practice meetings you were mostly reading Marx, or, I don't know, **Barnett Byron....., and Lathor (?? - 59.58)** and people, and so on. I mean, you weren't reading Simone de Beauvoir. But I do remember reading Juliet Mitchell and of course de Beauvoir and being very excited by that – that kind of approach – and thinking about it. So I think that was all going on in the later sixties if not before, and then

became much more central to my life. It made sense of things…

I [had been] aware that my mother's life was not one I wanted to live. I had, if you like, a negative identification of my mother. I really didn't want that life, and I knew that very early on. I couldn't abide the thought of being a full-time housewife or whatever. It just didn't have any appeal, and indeed, completely the opposite! (1, pp. 18-19)

7: Working for a Better World: Ethics and Religion

Quite early on I considered I would have a life outside of the home, and I thought I'd work for some international organisation, a charity of some sort, the UN even, I remember saying to someone! I didn't know what it was! The UN, what was it? But it sounded good, so I thought, "I'll do that, because I can use my languages, and I'll do good in the world". That was my thought, try and do something that would make things a bit better somehow, that was my inchoate thought when I was in my early teens.

So this idea of doing good in the world, what was the source of that would you think, then?

I dunno. India, the thing that I used to get very upset about in India, that I could do something about, was the appalling treatment of animals. So I set up a little charity when I think I was about eight or nine, and collected money to take to the equivalent of the RSPCA in India. So there was this sense that you needed to do something and make things a bit better, even if it was just for animals. And it's stayed with me in some transformed form, that what was the point of being in the world if you couldn't try and do things to make it better? Because living in India, what did you see? You saw the most appalling human misery. In those days you could meet lepers with half a face, you could meet people whose limbs had been chopped off so that they could beg more effectively, and this was a routine occurrence, you would see such people in the street. And we used to go to the beach quite a lot, so you'd go through the villages and you would see the way people lived, so those images stayed with you, albeit through a glass, they were very much part of the sensibility that I grew up with living in India, and then later Latin America.

Were you at all religious when you were younger?

My family wasn't particularly religious. My father, I think he was a conforming Christian who never went to church… We never went to church. I wasn't allowed to swear at home. I was sent to Sunday School, which I quite enjoyed, it was fun. I was Confirmed at the age of 15, I think, in the High Anglican church in Buenos Aires, but it was a bit a lark, we girls – there was a bunch of us – and we just thought it would be a bit of a lark and we didn't take in the least bit seriously. I also felt that Jesus let everybody down, because there was all this misery in the world, and he didn't stand up to his promise of saving little children or anything else. I became quite sceptic quite early on. (1, pp. 19-20)

8: State Socialism, Gender and Development

I couldn't go back to quite a lot of Latin America at that time [after 1976], [many] of the countries, after all, were under dictatorships of one kind or another. So I decided to focus instead on something rather different, to analyse, try to understand more about State Socialism and try to understand it from a gender perspective. I started this odyssey of going to lots of different State Socialist countries and thinking about that, and starting to write a book on it.

Well, it was, it was one of those things that Feminists didn't think about very much, and it was fascinating to me because it hadn't been thought about. I was involved, by that time, in small study groups of women working on women and development, and what would now be called "globalisation", … and there was a group at IDS – the Institute of Development Studies in Sussex – that I was working with during the mid-seventies, and we were all interested in this issue of developing countries, the global South. But nobody was working, or very few people were working on State Socialism…

But the first piece of empirical research I did was, of course, not in Latin America, but it was in Yemen, and that was purely because it was a UN Decade for Women. Which had opened in 1975 in Mexico, and which offered a kind of platform and a set of opportunities for people working with issues of gender and developing countries, so, so this opportunity - funding consultancies, lots of meetings, conferences, discussions, that was a very important sort of driver of my move into the more policy-related work that I have always been interested in doing. (1, p. 20)

9: Researching first generation women factory workers in Yemen

It started off with this study which I published with the ILO [International Labour Organisation] on Yemen, on first generation factory workers in the PDRY – the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen. That was pure happenstance that it came up, they needed someone, I said I'd do it. And Fred being someone very interested in Yemen said he'd come along, so we went together. I did the study, which was quite extensive when I thought back on it actually, it was a very extensive piece of research.

It was, again, completely serendipitous. Because I arrived in Aden, and I told them what I wanted to do, I had to get permission from the Ministry of Industry and actually permission from the President to do this research, because Yemen was a very closed society, the Yemeni Socialist Party was in control. We had a *murafiq*, who was our sort of invigilator. A *murafiq* is somebody who's assigned to you to keep an eye on you, and who accompanies you absolutely everywhere, and so it was under very controlled conditions that this research was carried out.

So, having got, in principle, permission, they wanted to see my questionnaire, so literally I was given 20 minutes to write the questionnaire, and I came up with 32 questions. It nearly resulted in me be thrown out of Yemen because I had a question which was to do with the time that people had free during the working day, and what they did with it. And this was a highly political question apparently, because there'd been strikes about this very question, and they thought that I was a provocateur. But the order to expel me was overruled by, I think it was Abdul Fatah I was told later, and so I was granted permission but with that question removed. (LAUGHS)

So I embarked on this study, really, in the most abject of conditions that you could possibly imagine. I have written, somewhere, that I couldn't have chosen a more difficult area for research than a State Socialist country in the Middle East, actually! Given that we had all the problems, or I had all the problems of the security services on top of me all the time, and controlled conditions in the interview setting, and I had to actually ask for some people to be removed from the room because they were Party people assigned to keep an eye on things. And so it was quite a tense but fascinating experience.

You succeeded in getting them to do this?

Yes. Yes. Absolutely. I would ask for individuals [to interview], and I might be given some, and I would ask for group interviews and might be given some. Every site, you went along not knowing what you were going to succeed in getting, it was that precarious. But the most co-operative was the Sheik Othman Chinese textile factory which I think they were very proud of, and so they let me interview a lot of people, a lot of women, there, and I had both group interviews and some one-to-one's, and some key informant interviews there. And then the smaller places like the matchstick factory were fascinating. And some of the little craft sites that I went to where you had women making items of ironmongery, so there was lots of different sites and it was absolutely fascinating – that research...

We did go out of Aden a few times to some of the smaller factories, but of course, the big textile factory was in Sheik Othman, which is part of Aden… But yes, I was quite lucky that I got so much information because it is, to this day, the only study [of this kind] that's been done, there's very little research on the PDRY. I spent a very interesting couple of hours with some Yemeni scholars the other day who were keen to have all my field notes, because from the two trips I made to Aden, to Yemen, because there's hardly any research, and so it was a miracle that this got done at all, to be honest – given the conditions, the timing, the fact that I had to learn basic Arabic to carry out the questions.

I taped everything, but obviously I don't speak Arabic, so I had to learn enough Arabic to pose the questions, and enough conversational Arabic to be able to say, “How are you?” and “That was very good”, and “Thank you very much”, and this kind of thing. But it had its hazards, and it's one of the reasons that there was no way I was going to stay working on the Middle East. Not to be able to speak the language was, for me, a devastating absence, and I knew I would never want to write anything again on the Middle East. I happened to do more work on Yemen again, serendipitously, some years later. Again, it was a fascinating trip, but that was a more theoretical, what I wrote after that was more theoretical, about law and society, and social change. But that research was very - it was the first real engagement with research rather than theory, that book that I did for the ILO.

I think you talked to quite a lot of other people who weren't factory workers.

A lot of people in villages and also key informants who happened to be, you know, people in Ministries, or that kind of person. So I did 120 interviews with factory workers, and about 50 others with different people, [such as] nurses, just to get a sense of the gender situation for women in this extraordinary short-lived Socialist State. It was an extraordinary experience –

looking back on it – and particularly the misery of the poor Yemenis living now. (1, pp. 20-3)

You did all these interviews, but you don't actually quote from them. You've just got tables.

Yes. I really would have found that quite difficult to manage in the sense that I had lots and lots of notes, and it wasn't the style of writing an ILO report at that time. I also felt, somehow, that my distance from the language would make it less easy to do, because my translations would have been fairly inaccurate, they would have been rather impressionistic. So I didn't get around to quoting as such, for quite a long time – I mean, much later. Yes, I think it was the nature of the beast that I was writing that dictated the final presentation, so it is lots of statistics and it was a headache because it all had to be coded - you know, in those days when you had it all on cards? So it was all on these yellow cards and coding and it was an absolute nightmare. And again, thanks to Essex, I was able to pay for a coder to do the work! And wrestling with all the print-outs, which was a huge amount of stuff. I think it's all in the attic somewhere, I'll probably have to keep it for posterity because there's nothing else on Yemen! (1, pp. 32-3)

10: Women in a Socialist Yemen

I taught Comparative Sociology. I was interested in looking comparatively at countries, across countries, didn't have to be comparing with Latin America, I was just fascinated by the challenge of what was different and what was specific, but also where were the continuities? And that's why I was terribly interested, intellectually, in this problem of these State Socialist countries because, they asked for answers to a whole range of questions both in development theory and in gender theory, and so, for me, that was the interesting thing. Why was Yemen interesting? Because here was a Middle Eastern country doing with exactly the same policies that were played out in the Soviet Union, and yet look at the difference in the effects, look at the difference in the culture, look at the difference in the whole political processes at work. So it was that comparative lens, I think, that's always been a very compelling part of my intellectual interest.

What did you feel about the position of women in Yemen?

Well, it was, of course, highly marked by class and status. So you could see that the most impoverished, the most badly-treated women were also the "Akhdam" class, who were almost a caste of ex-slaves who had come largely from Sudan, and who were, in some ways, regarded as not quite an untouchable class: so there were parallels there with India. But in general the position of women in a country like Yemen was pretty poor in terms of rights and choices, and ability to occupy a place in the world of their own making. So it very clearly was one of the most challenging contexts, I think, to do research on gender issues. Yemen, in general, of course, has some of the worst human development indicators on women: you have very early marriages, you have high rates of infant mortality, female mortality and morbidity and so on. And here was a country in the South, that for colonial reasons was somewhat separate, had been governed somewhat separately, and which had a Socialist Party trying to make a difference. So it was fascinating to see if it did, to what extent it did. What was it doing? How effective was what it was doing – against this cultural background?

Now, of course, you can't easily compare North and South [Yemen] because the North was never colonised, the South was. There'd always been a British presence of trained nurses, and had brought women into certain kind of skills, and that did make a difference [from] the North. So it was interesting thinking about that colonial legacy and the impact of a Socialist Party trying to introduce the new family law, new forms of justice, encouraging girls into education and so on, but within the backdrop of a very patriarchal society.

So did you make recommendations?

Oh yes. I've got to dig out that report, but it would be, I guess, to encourage women's skill training, the usual package of improvements within industry, but also more widely in society, and also to pick out some of the things that were working better as a result of government intervention. I think it was odd, because in the UN Decade for Women, they would fix on a country or a region to do these regional reports, or these country case studies, so the Yemen Report was selected for evaluation, to look at whether progress for women was happening in these various things, so my report was really part of that UN Decade for Women for this kind of thing.

I think your original interest was partly because it was Muslim as well as Socialist?

Well, it is certainly very interesting, and partly because I was very impressed by reading

about Soviet Central Asia, and how Lenin had actually sought to transform Soviet Central Asia by liberating women. It's a wonderful book called *The Surrogate Proletariat*, where women were seen as a kind of substitute for a proletariat in societies that had no proletariat. I was really interested in this kind of notion, and had thought a lot about Central Asia, and, indeed, went to Afghanistan and also to Central Asia – Uzbekistan on one occasion, thanks to Essex University supporting my trip! So I was very interested in that sort of encounter between a modernising Socialist State, and a Muslim society, and so, yes, so Yemen was interesting, as was Afghanistan, and Iraq actually, yes.

How far did you feel that really fundamental changes in belief were needed to help women to be able to fulfil themselves?

I thought it was absolutely essential, and probably one of the most difficult things to achieve, but the only real vehicle for that could be education, actually, in a society which had very little access to public media. But these customs and attitudes, as we all know, are very much more deeply ingrained, especially when fortified by religious belief that is very strong. The degree to which Aden was different helps to explain why some progress here was made, because Aden being a port was more open, you had actually – in the sixties – a Socialist trades union movement. So there were forces of transformational change already taking place prior to the advent of the Yemeni Socialist Party, plus the role of Arab Nationalism was quite strong in this time, and that was, itself, a modernising force. I mean, the very first Nationalist constitutions in the Arab world gave women equal rights – at least in theory – they transformed some of the family law, and that was the kind of secularising Nationalism. It wasn't fully secularising, but it had some secular elements to it. So all of those influences prepared the way in Aden, at least with some progress, for women – not so much outside, not in the hinterlands...

Although I must say, the first time I went to Yemen in '77, they did have a national literacy programme, they got the Akhdam women organised into schools and educated them. They did things. You could see that girls were going to school, even up in the Hadramaut which was like a lovely mountainous area in Yemen. But when I went back in 1984 and visited some of the same areas, the girls had been taken out of school. Partly this was because of the Saudis. The Yemenis had gone to Saudi Arabia, had come back, and had taken their wives out of the fields and put them in the home and had veiled them when they went out. So there was a real cultural change that had happened – retrograde, in my view – that

took place in that intervening period, as a result of the influence of Saudi, or the experience of the migrants in Saudi Arabia.

And was violence against women an issue?

Well, it was an issue, but it was not talked about. Violence took the form of revenge killings or honour killings of women. In the second trip I was on a mission for the UN, to look at the health and the health conditions of women, I had with me a woman who worked in the Ministry of Health, who was a very talented woman, and her life story was astonishing. She had been not educated, but had educated herself, borrowing books from her father. She belonged to one of the very powerful – there are two big Hadrami families, big clans – she belonged to one of them, and again, from a powerful family. She actually ran away to Aden when she was in her teens, was educated in a Nursing School that the British ran. The parents took out a death warrant on her, to have her killed for disobeying orders. She was only saved by a son of the other Hadrami family offering to marry her. So it gives you a flavour of just how difficult even high born women could find life in those days, and until recently, there was, yes, quite a lot of honour killings. So, yes, it's clearly a very big issue. Much worse in the North, or was much worse in the North, where you had the practice of young girls being married off to very old men, and if they said no, they'd even be put in prison. Some cases I got involved in the North about that. So yes, a harsh society for women, to say the least. (1, pp. 24-7)

11: Innovation and Isolation: Development, Feminism, Anthropology and Social Policy

You were making these recommendations, did you ever talk about that kind of thing with the social policy people in England, including Essex?

Not really, no… I don't think there was much overlap there, I didn't think there were many people interested. I constantly got the impression from my senior colleagues at Essex, or men, some of them, that what I was doing was really not very interesting and rather marginal… So there wasn't much conversation across, partly because, in all fairness, there were no experts in my field.

Were there anthropologists who were experts?

No… I felt that I was in a bit of, yes, a bit of my own lagoon, plying up and down! But where did I have any real contact? I suppose mostly with development. I mean, teaching the M.Sc. Development with Harold, there was a bit more conversation about things.

Feminism, again I was an offshore Feminist. I wasn't, in any way, connected with the BSA Feminists, the British School Feminists, they were doing something totally different, and they weren't interested. The people who really I had the most intellectual interaction with were people working in Gender and Development, which was an area we pioneered, in fact [in the British context]. I mean, that group, we called ourselves "The Subordination of Women Group", I think established some very different ways of doing and thinking about research in the global South, from a gender perspective, and that's where my most immediate interaction, intellectual engagement, was with. And it was a very new area of development… that has now become very mainstream…

It was that world that was where the intellectual nourishment was, where you got some feedback, you got some recognition. It wasn't within British sociology as such… Of course, the Yemen, that didn't really – except within a small group of Middle-Eastern studies people. So again, I think the theme I'm becoming aware of as I talk, is that this sense of being an outsider continued, actually, for pretty much throughout my career – which is an odd thing to say, isn't it! It's certainly how I felt. Probably something very deep and primal! (1, pp, 28-29)

12: Afghanistan and Yemen: Dangers in Fieldwork

Well, there were some dangerous bits, yes. There were some dangerous places. I think when you're young, you don't think of risk so much, do you, you head off into it, and it's quite exciting. But looking back, I was a risk-taker, and I didn't mind that, it didn't affect me at first. I think the time I was most aware of my own mortality was in Afghanistan, when Fred and I went in 1980, and it was just after the Russians invaded, and it was a very unpleasant, frightening trip, because we were targets – I mean, we looked Russian apparently. We both had leather jackets and jeans on, and that's what Russians wore, and we stood out. We were taken around in armoured personnel vehicles and such like, it was terrible. And we were told

that So and So had been blown up yesterday, and a German TV crew in Herat had been killed in exactly the same spot…

[In Yemen] I got ill on the, now that was the first trip, wasn't it. Yes. So I was up in Dahle … a very rural area, but we were staying in one of the colonial houses that Brits would be put up in, and I can remember being treated to this lunch, with a great big picture of Lenin behind the Party Secretary who was entertaining us, and about three hours or less later, I was absolutely so ill, iller than I've ever been in my life I think. And so that night I got worse and worse and worse, and in the morning this delegation of people arrived to treat me, and there was a nurse in her *abaya* with filthy hands and nails, holding this hypodermic syringe, her assistant with the saline bottle, and the Party Secretary and two other people – hangers on of some sort – all came advancing on me in my sick bed, presumably to give me a saline drip, and I knew, if I had that, I would be dead within minutes, literally. So I seized the bottle, and said, "I will, I'll take it". "No ... *la, la, la* to the needle", and so I uncorked it and drank it! That stopped them!

But I was very ill. I was lifted out, I think. I can't even remember, because we'd got the six hours in the Land-Rover along a river bed, and so there was no way I could go back. So I think they lifted me out by plane, and I arrived in Aden Hospital and yes, apparently I had – I spoke to a Yemeni doctor, actually, recently, and he said, "You had a toxic attack, and then you probably had geodarsis", which I know I had, but it was worse than anything I've ever had. So I'm alive today, thanks to not allowing them to give me an intravenous drip. So, important to be vigilant! (1, pp. 29-30)

13: Researching Marxist-Leninism in Ethiopia

And then from Yemen, because Ethiopia was just across the border, and it was another revolutionary situation, Fred was very keen to go, and he said, "Why don't we both go?" We'd met quite a few people from the Horn of Africa in Aden, and so Fred wanted to go to the Horn of Africa, and I said, "Well, I'll go to Ethiopia". So we went to Ethiopia as well, and it was part of this oddity round the developing countries in the Socialist world, so to speak. We spent some time there doing research on Ethiopia, and got very taken with it, very interested in it, and that, of course, ended up being a book that we wrote together. So it was a huge departure from Latin America, but it didn't feel all that alien to me. I felt, well, "Let's find out

things and learn about things and different places and try your best". (1, p. 24)

We went to Ethiopia at the worst possible time. It was the time of the "Red Terror" in 1977, which lasted till 1978, and it was under the Derg and things were very tense. Indeed, that was a pretty, pretty dangerous trip in some ways. There was a lot going on. People were being murdered, bodies in the street, there was this confrontation – fatal confrontation between the student movement and the military – which was to, to repeat itself, of course, in Latin America, in very different ways. But so we were taken around a lot, to be shown the triumph of the revolution, but of course we also - you could meet with academics, you could meet with people, you could talk to the students, but you had to be a bit careful how you did it. But we saw quite a bit of what the derg was doing, including at the airport, rows and rows of the Collected Works of Lenin. Again, one of these extraordinary historical moments. To think of imposing a Marxist-Leninist regime on a country like Ethiopia, let alone Yemen, there was something extraordinarily surreal about it, and yet people were mobilised, people were involved in these activities of citizen action and the "Kebelle" system modelled on the Cuban Committees for the Defence of the Revolution in that that particular locality, so again, there were these continuities and discontinuities, because of the different cultural formations. So Ethiopia was fascinating.

We wanted to write about it when we got back, because I was interested in a somewhat theoreticist manner, in the whole Skocpol work on comparative revolutions in *States and Social Revolution*. I was very interested, again, in thinking comparatively and so Ethiopia was a good case. And, of course, we had to do lots of research when we got back, to put in context what we had learnt when we were there. And so it was a bit of a challenge, that book, because neither of us are specialists on Ethiopia, so we had to do a lot of reading and investigation when we got back. And we went again to try and mop up some of what we hadn't been able to do the first time round.

We tried to write this book together, which was difficult! Difficult, but not unpleasant, but I think both of us felt that it had been a bit of a struggle, because we both were, perhaps, somewhat single-minded about what we wanted to do, and so we ended up doing different chapters and trying to string them together at the end… I ended up writing this book on state socialism, but completing it just as that whole system collapsed, the Soviet Union collapsed in 1989/90, and that was the end.

I didn't publish it… I did chapters on law, education, the family, they're all upstairs, but I never - the appetite went, I just thought, "What's the point? It's, it's over". It was a largely theory-driven book, so it didn't seem right to publish it at that point, so it languishes,

lashing unseen! (LAUGHS) Well, you have to move on. (1, pp. 30-2)

14: Women in the Age of Perestroika

I went to Russia. I went to Hungary, so, and I was actually involved in some sociological groups working on poverty at that time, at the Max Weber Institute in Hungary, and so there was a kind of cross-over. Some of the work I was doing on Latin America was of interest to the people from former Soviet Union… In the early nineties. And I did do some fieldwork, a bit, but more in the form of interviews, trying to access some data that you couldn't easily get here, that kind of thing…

It wasn't a research project of a kind that either the Yemen had been, or later research had been, or even archival research, it was more journalistic, it was sort of trying to find out as much as you can, and interview everybody you can meet, and get some information. It was a more conceptually driven piece than anything else, I would say…

You say when you went to the Soviet Union in the 1980s, you found yourself with a tired population, and a disheartened intellectual elite.

Oh, absolutely. Absolutely. It was, it was palpable. You went to people's houses and they were feeling there was very little they could say in public, but there was a lot going on, there was a lot of – just disillusionment. I also remember speaking to some Polish sociologists as well, towards the end of the eighties and they just said, "The system's finished". I was quite shocked that it was so clear to them, because we didn't know it was going to collapse, did we, in such an extraordinarily short space of time. It was a case of history accelerating at an extraordinarily surprising speed.

But the intimations were there in the later eighties. People were talking about how can it go on? It can't go on. I remember talking to David Lockwood about it, and he just said, "How can you expect any country that doesn't allow migration in the modern world, to survive?" Because of the pressure-cooker element. There's no outlet for people's accumulating frustrations, he thought. But I don't think it was necessarily just migration, I think it was the broader pressures on people, their everyday life was so exhausting. And the intelligentsia were very frustrated because they couldn't get access to things, they couldn't

travel very much. Some were let out for periods of time, and then came back even more discontented. So you just felt that people were just waiting for change, and something might happen, but it could have gone on for another ten years, you could easily think. But it's one of the surprises of history, just how these things suddenly just collapse. (1, pp. 35-6)

15: Nicaragua, Gender and Revolution

I went to Nicaragua with a Nuffield Grant in 1982, to do some work on the issue around gender and revolution, and I did a lot of interviewing there… I don't know, 30 or 40 interviews, with mostly political people, yes. And try and get a handle on what they were up to in Nicaragua, in terms of policy process, and the gender issues and so on and so forth, and again, it was a very theory-driven question. I came up with this particular way of thinking about the way that people talk about whether they have a gender, or woman-friendly set of policies, and then you would look into them and you would see that, actually, they're not doing very much to change the context within which women's equality is simply being reproduced, so how do we think about that problem? And that was the article I wrote on women's interest – trying to disaggregate this notion of interest – that came to my mind as I looked at the Nicaraguan case in some detail.

Of course, it was such a critical distinction, thinking about women's interests and breaking them down into what I called "practical interests" and "strategic interests", practical being those that arise out of basic needs, and those strategic interests which would be the more transformative conception of how would you bring about change for women to open up their opportunities and give them more choices and so on. But that distinction then became very much used in the international development policy world, and it entered into loads of research projects and policy statements, and all kinds of things. So quite outside of Nicaragua, it became one of those frameworks that had currency in the world of the UN Decade, with all its conferences and its meetings and its global Women's Movement. It was a very, a very important time for people who wanted to influence the way policy was thought about in terms of gender equality, and, and that was a big opportunity for those of us who had been working for some time in the gender and development field, and had been really trying to push the boundaries of how you conceptualise gender and equality in a way that can also kind of engage public policy…

Did you find Nicaragua inspiring? It became a flagship place, didn't it?

It did. It did. Well, I went with slightly sceptical eyes, because of the failures of these states to really respond in a profound way to the deeper structural forces that led to women's inequality being perpetuated, and also the authoritarian and patriarchal elements within the culture of Nicaragua, which have shown themselves to be quite extreme in the period recently. But, yes, I went with optimism. I thought that there were things they were doing that were very positive in terms of the broader policies of education, literacy, the things they said, the changes in the laws that they made, the usual things. And then there was the revolutionary fervour, there was the fact that people were so very enthusiastic, and brimming over with optimism and engagement, which is very contagious. And they got rid of the dictator they had. They were still fighting a war, the contra war, supported by the US, and it was an extraordinary time to be there – just to be alive.

But, of course, you could already see some of the lines that were forming, that were less positive, particularly on issues of reproductive rights, that was not tackled head on, and nor could it possibly have been, given the context. But it hardened, attitudes hardened against Feminism later on, under the presidency of Ortega, so a lot of bad things happened later on. At the time, in '82, it was fairly optimistic times. When I went back again, very different. Very much darker scenario. And literally, Feminism was a bad word, it was being hounded by the government, and women's demonstrations were being severely repressed by the police. It was a nasty situation, and, and an alliance between the formerly revolutionary leadership with the most Right-wing of the Catholic Church, ensured that women's reproductive rights and much more besides would not make much progress henceforth. So it was a kind of a sad arc, which started well, and ended badly…

Then, of course, Cuba. I was able to get re-engaged with Cuba. I'd first been there in 1980… I didn't go down very well in Cuba! But it was fascinating, and things were gradually changing in Cuba a little bit, and I kept up that interest and did more work on Cuba… and then did some research on the Cuban Diaspora in Miami, which was very fascinating. I thought, "You can't understand Cuba without understanding the obsession of the Cuban leadership with the diaspora. And so what is this diaspora? Let's look at it. Let's talk to them. Let's find out what they are, and who they are". I did a very interesting piece of research on that, and found out that there were different generations of diaspora and that mattered, the politics were all different. It was an interesting, slightly off-centre view of

Cuba, seen from Miami – completed my picture a little bit more. It was good to do it. (1, pp. 36-8)

16: Mothers and Social Protection in Latin America, Africa and the Middle East

Now that was a big project. It started off in Mexico [in the early 2000s]. I got interested in social policy, and had been doing quite a lot of work on poverty and anti-poverty programmes, and I went to Mexico to give some talks, and I got invited to see some of these programmes. So I spent some time with the people who designed the programmes, and we went to three sites, and I did some interviews with the women, and it got me thinking a lot about the way that these anti-poverty programmes were missing the whole gender analysis issue. So once again I was intrigued to see, if you thought about this differently, how would you redesign these programmes? And what would be the basis of the critique of the way that they are currently conceptualised? And that piece was the first stab at this, and I wrote it up in a different way for the *Journal of Social Policy*, and that piece practically went viral in Latin America… That opened up a whole new kind of avenue of consultancies and research projects that I did for DIFID, or Care International….

I was interested in social protection, by which, today, we mean basically thinking about providing a social floor for people, so they don't fall through the net and have no social security, in a sense – it's social security. But I got very interested in this conditional cash transfer model that was rolled out in Latin America and had been writing about it, and that became part of the work that I've continued to do in different ways since then… One project, for example, was for Care International, which was to look at cash transfers and their impact on women in three Andean countries in Latin America, and so we did this comparative project with teams working in each of the three countries – Bolivia, Ecuador, and Peru – and focus group interviews, in-depth research, all the rest of it.

That was relatively quite a big project, but it wasn't anything like as big as the next one that came along, which was in 2012, where I was appointed Research Director by ODI and DIFID to lead on a big five country research project in the Middle East and Africa, looking at the beneficiaries' perceptions of cash transfers. So there'd been an awful lot of work looking at large-scale surveys, looking at the impact on child health, nutrition and so on, but there hadn't been very much qualitative research asking the beneficiaries what

difference having this cash transfer actually made to their lives. So we did a very thorough piece of research in five countries, using local teams, and developed a very complex and thorough variety of methodologies, to poverty map, and to establish life course histories, different methods to elicit this information in these five countries. And that was, that was probably the biggest project that I had responsibility for… It was a very stressful time, because DIFID wanted this research done in one year - which was a very very short period of time for the scale of the research that, that we were doing in all these different countries, which were not easy countries to research in, particularly Yemen. We did Palestine and Yemen, and three African countries, so it was quite a big project.

The local teams did the fieldwork, and my role was to design, to work with the two people closest to me, to design the research methodology and the research questions, and the on the ground directions to the teams. So it was at a distance, but it was very engaged because this was, I think, the most intensive project that I've ever been involved in, at every stage, and with a lot of co-ordination across, made possible by modern technology, which would not have been possible in the days of Yemen. But it was very interesting research, and I think they were very pleased with it – DIFID was very pleased with it, it got a top ranking, and they liked it, and we published a report on each country, a very detailed report on each country, and an overall synthesis report. And we had some people in certain sites doing their own visual accounts, so they took their own photographs and made their own films, so that was involving the beneficiaries themselves in telling their own stories about how it had changed their lives or not, or what the problems were. (1, pp. 40-2)